

Hindsight bias

Studies of American World War II soldiers

reviewed and commented by sociologist Paul Lazarsfeld, here is the sample:

1. Better-educated soldiers suffered more adjustment problems than did lesseducated soldiers. (Intellectuals were less prepared for battle stresses than were street-smart people.)

Studies of American World War II soldiers

2. Southern soldiers coped better with the hot South Sea Island climate than did Northern soldiers. (Southerners are more accustomed to hot weather.)

Studies of American World War II soldiers

3. White privates were more eager for promotion than were Black privates. (Years of oppression take a toll on achievement motivation.)

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4. Southern Blacks preferred Southern to Northern White officers. (Southern officers were more experienced and skilled in interacting with Blacks.)

IS SOCIAL PSYCHOLOGY SIMPLY COMMON SENSE?

social psychology is:

The scientific study of how people think about, influence, and relate to one another.

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=> study of:

- Social thinking
- Social influence
- Social relations

is social psychology just common sense in fancy words?

- philosophers, novelists, and poets have observed and commented on social behavior
- own experience
- social psychology studies common sense questions?

Writer Cullen Murphy (1990):

“Day after day social scientists go out into the world. Day after day they discover that people’s behavior is pretty much what you’d expect”

Paul Lazarsfeld:

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Also Paul Lazarsfeld:

“Every one of these statements is the direct opposite of what was actually found.”

In reality, the studies found that less-educated soldiers adapted more poorly.

Southerners were not more likely than northerners to adjust to a tropical climate.

Blacks were more eager than Whites for promotion.

So forth..

“If we had mentioned the actual results of the investigation first, the reader would have labeled these ‘obvious’ also.”

One problem with common sense is that we invoke it after we know the facts.

Events are far more “obvious” and predictable in hindsight than beforehand.

Experiments reveal that when people learn the outcome of an experiment, that outcome suddenly seems unsurprising—much less surprising than it is to people who are simply told about the experimental procedure and the possible outcomes (Slovic & Fischhoff, 1977).

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Also known as the **I-knew-it-all-along phenomenon**

- oral exams, or when we now know the answer on that test questions
- arrrgg!! I studied it!! how could i not figure it out on the test!!

9/11

Before 9/11

- Everything is fine?

After 9/11

- How could we not connect those facts together? It is obvious! Somebody should be fired!



9/11

The CIA knew that al Qaeda operatives had entered the country.

An FBI agent sent a memo to headquarters that began by warning:

“the Bureau and New York of the possibility of a coordinated effort by Osama bin Laden to send students to the United States to attend civilian aviation universities and colleges.”

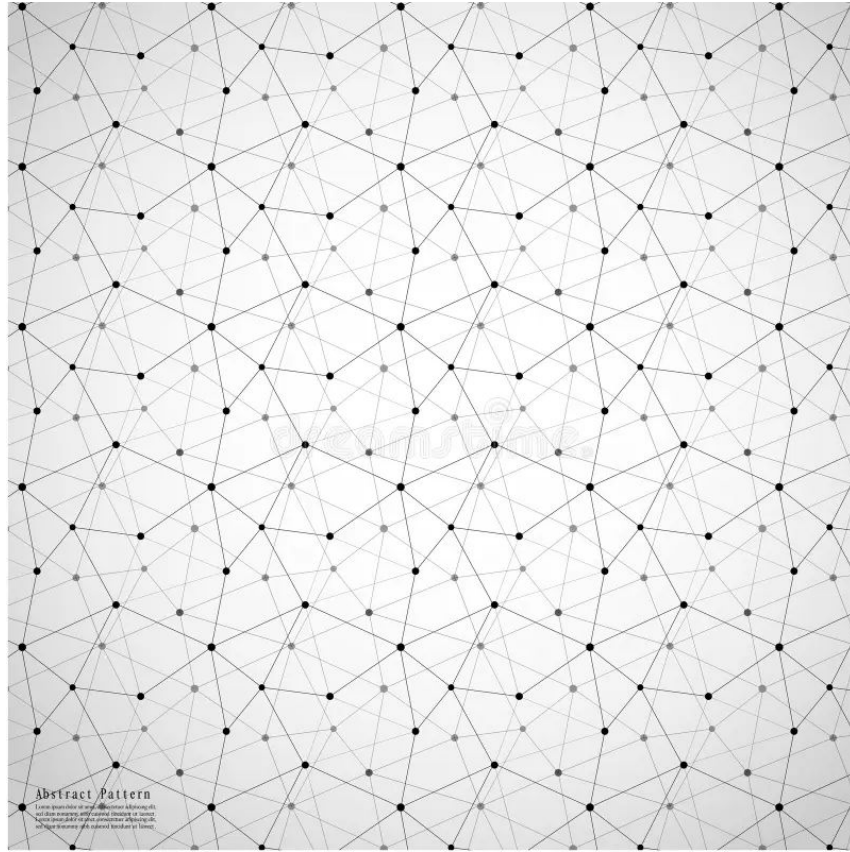
9/11

Hindsight critics:

“The dumb fools!”

“Why couldn’t they connect the dots?”

The dots:



Hindsight bias may lead to:

- Arrogance to others
- Unnecessary anger/frustration
- Internalization of own mistakes (negative remarks about yourself)

What is important to understand is that **hindsight bias is not an excuse for everything**